



DIAPHRAGMA

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PLAYERS RULEBOOK

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What Is Diaphragma?

WHAT IS DIAPHRAGMA?



Welcome to **Diaphragma**, a modular narrative RPG built for fast, cinematic play, expressive storytelling and designed to be expanded through setting Frameworks. You'll read the room, find the angle, use your surroundings, exploit the weakness, and strike when everything lines up. When the dice hit the table, you've already done the work. Let's tell great stories!

The guard patrols the same arc. Every thirty seconds, the doorway is empty.

You've counted four passes. The lantern inside throws his shadow before he reaches the window — that's your warning. The mud will muffle your steps. The broken shutter gives you two handholds.

You don't move until the moment is right. When you do, it counts.

Each story runs on a **Framework**, a setting layer your Storyteller picks that gives you the world, the threats, and the tone. The rules handle the rest.

WHAT YOU NEED

DICE One d10.

SHEETS Character sheets PDF

Why This Book Exists

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

I've been running games for a while. Long enough to have opinions.

D&D has something people underestimate: the round. Initiative sounds like a limitation. Players treat it like a cage. But that turn order is doing real work. Every player, no matter how quiet, no matter how much they're still figuring out what their character would do, gets a moment. The round finds them. That structure holds space for people.

But the system fights you. A player spots something. They describe an action that's creative and physical and alive. And I have to stop and figure out which stat applies, what the DC is, whether there's a proficiency here. By the time I've sorted it out, something's gone. The scene was happening. Now it isn't.

Narrative games solve that. **Powered by the Apocalypse, Blades in the Dark** — get out of the way of your players. One roll. Let the fiction breathe.

Until you notice who's doing most of the talking. The aggressive players. The ones who move first because the answer is always yes. The quiet player building toward something, waiting for the right moment — nobody's waiting for them. There is no turn. There's just whoever speaks next.

This game is an attempt to hold both things at once.

One die. One moment. The fiction drives everything. And a structure that makes space for every player at the table, not just the one who moves fastest.

CINEMATIC

One roll. One strong scene moment. No sluggish turns.

RESOURCEFUL

The room is your toolkit. The chandelier. The darkness. The guard's old wound.

EXPRESSIVE

No stat blocks. No class lists. Your character is their history.

MODULAR

The core is a skeleton. Frameworks are the flesh.

If you're a GM who wants to tinker, this is for you. If you're a player who wants to tell a great story without the rules getting in the way, this is for you. If you've ever had a quiet character who never got their moment, this is especially for you.

Core Concepts

CORE CONCEPTS

SETTLE OR ROLL

Play it safe (**Settle**, raw result = 5) or risk it (**Roll**, 1d10). One die. No pools. You choose every time.

EDGES & BAINS

Favorable fiction adds +1 per Edge.
Unfavorable fiction subtracts. The scene around you matters as much as the die.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

A result of 7–9. You get what you wanted — but it costs you something. **The game lives here.**

NARRATIVE POINTS

A shared group currency earned from dramatic moments. Spend to reroll, inject a scene fact, or help an ally.

DESIGN GOALS

CINEMATIC One roll, one strong scene moment

RESOURCEFUL Gear, terrain, allies, information

SETUP-DRIVEN Create openings, don't grind

EXPRESSIVE Built from experience, not stat arrays

MODULAR Frameworks add the genre layer

NARRATIVE-FIRST Fiction first, rules second

FRAMEWORKS

The core rules are not the whole game.

Diaphragma is designed to be paired with a Framework — a campaign layer that adds what the core intentionally leaves open:

SETTING

ARCHETYPES

GEAR

ADVANCEMENT

STONE

POWERS

ENEMIES

SPECIAL RULES

A horror Framework adds panic, injury, and fragile gear. A cyberpunk Framework adds hacking, cyberware, and corporate heat. A mythic fantasy Framework adds oaths, relics, and divine bargains. **The same core engine supports all of them.**

How to Read This Book

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

IF YOU'RE A PLAYER

Read **Chapters 1–3**. Start with Chapter 1 to understand how the game works, then Chapter 2 to build your character.

IF YOU'RE THE STORYTELLER

Read everything. Chapter 4 is yours. The Back Matter has all tables and reference sheets.

